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NOETHER'S THEOREM AND THE CASIMIR HONEYCOMB DRIVE: ON NON-CONSERVATION OF MOMENTUM IN ASYMMETRIC VACUUM SYSTEMS

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In this paper the Casimir honeycomb drive is analyzed with the help of Noether's theorem. The system under consideration - a perfectly conducting plate with a nanoscale honeycomb structure on one side - lacks translational symmetry along the axis normal to the plate due to the geometric asymmetry of vacuum modes on its sides. As a consequence, the vacuum Hamiltonian depends explicitly on the coordinate l (the effective cavity length), and by Noether's theorem, the corresponding component of momentum is not conserved. This non-conservation manifests as a net quantum-vacuum force (Casimir thrust). It is shown that the derived expression for the force per unit area directly reflects this broken symmetry and is consistent with both Hamiltonian approach and the difference in the energy density. The result underscores a profound physical principle: macroscopic thrust from quantum vacuum fluctuations arises because the system is not invariant under spatial translations.

Keywords: *Noether's theorem, Casimir effect, quantum vacuum, non-conservation of momentum, nanohoneycomb, Casimir thrust*

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INTRODUCTION

Noether's theorem establishes a profound correspondence between continuous symmetries of a physical system and conserved values of quantities. In particular, invariance under spatial translations implies conservation of linear momentum. In the classical two-plate Casimir configuration, the system remains symmetric under translations perpendicular to the plates, so transverse momentum is conserved; only the normal component is affected by boundary conditions.

In contrast, the *one-body* Casimir honeycomb drive breaks translational symmetry explicitly along the z-axis due to different boundary conditions on the different sides of a single plate: one side being smooth and another structured with conductive nanocavities. This asymmetry renders the vacuum Hamiltonian $\langle 0|\hat{\mathscr{H}}|0\rangle$ a function of the geometric parameter l, which represents the effective length of the nanocavities.

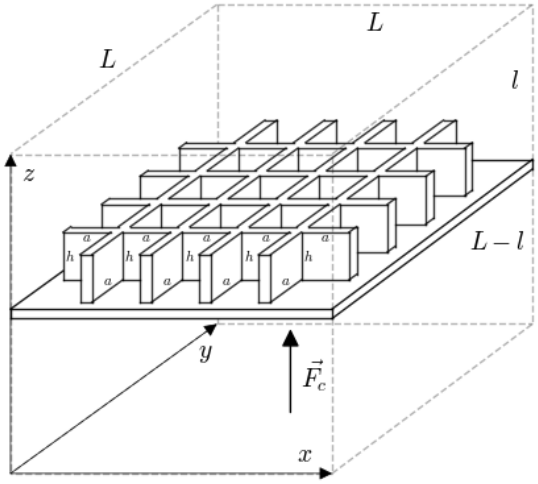


Fig.1. Cubic cavity with a plate covered by honeycomb.

NOETHER'S THEOREM AND MOMENTUM NON-CONSERVATION

Let us consider the vacuum Hamiltonian per unit area derived for the honeycomb system:

$$\frac{\langle 0|\hat{\mathscr{H}}|0\rangle}{S} = \frac{\hbar c}{a^2\pi}\left\{ l \sum_{n_x=(0)1}^{\infty}\sum_{n_y=(0)1}^{\infty}\int_0^{\infty}\sqrt{\frac{\pi^2}{a^2}(n_x^2+n_y^2)+k_z^2}\,dk_z + (L-l)\int_0^{\infty}\int_0^{\infty}\int_0^{\infty}\sqrt{k_x^2+k_y^2+k_z^2}\,dk_z\,\frac{a}{\pi}dk_x\frac{a}{\pi}dk_y\right\}.$$

This expression depends explicitly on l. Hence, the system is **not invariant** under infinitesimal translations $z \to z+\delta z$.

According to Noether's theorem, the generator of spatial translations—momentum component P_z — is conserved **if and only if** the Hamiltonian is independent of z. Since $\partial\langle H\rangle/\partial l \neq 0$, the symmetry is broken, and P_z is not conserved.

The resulting force is

$$\frac{F}{S} = \frac{\partial}{\partial l}\frac{\langle 0|\hat{\mathscr{H}}|0\rangle}{S} = \frac{\hbar c}{a^2\pi}\left\{ \sum_{n_x=(0)1}^{\infty}\sum_{n_y=(0)1}^{\infty}\int_0^{\infty}\sqrt{\frac{\pi^2}{a^2}(n_x^2+n_y^2)+k_z^2}\,dk_z - \int_0^{\infty}\int_0^{\infty}\int_0^{\infty}\sqrt{k_x^2+k_y^2+k_z^2}\,dk_z\,dn_x dn_y\right\},$$

which matches the Casimir thrust formula previously obtained via the difference in energy density.

Thus, the appearance of net thrust is not unexpected - it is the consequence of a broken translational symmetry. The quantum vacuum "pushes" more strongly on one side because the quantun vacuum oscillation mode structure differs, and Noether's theorem provides the fundamental explanation why momentum does not need to be conserved.

ON THE INCOMPLETENESS OF THE STANDARD MOMENTUM BALANCE

It is essential to specify which momentum is not conserved, so that the result is not misread as a violation of a fundamental conservation law. The standard momentum-balance equation of continuum electrodynamics (Tamm, § 105) reads

$$\nabla\cdot\mathbf{T} = \frac{\partial \mathbf{g}}{\partial t} + \mathbf{f}_{\rm vol}, \qquad \mathbf{g} = \frac{1}{c^2}\mathbf{S} = \frac{1}{4\pi c}[\mathbf{E}\times\mathbf{H}],$$

where $\mathbf{T}$ is the Maxwell stress tensor, $\mathbf{g}$ the field momentum density and $\mathbf{f}_{\rm vol}$ the volume (ponderomotive) force density. For the vacuum fluctuations of a static honeycomb system the mean Poynting vector vanishes, $\langle\mathbf{S}\rangle = 0$, hence $\langle\partial\mathbf{g}/\partial t\rangle = 0$.

The customary identification of the field momentum with

$\mathbf{g} = \mathbf{S}/c^2$ therefore misses the contribution that remains: the surface integral of the stress tensor over the boundary of the vacuum region.

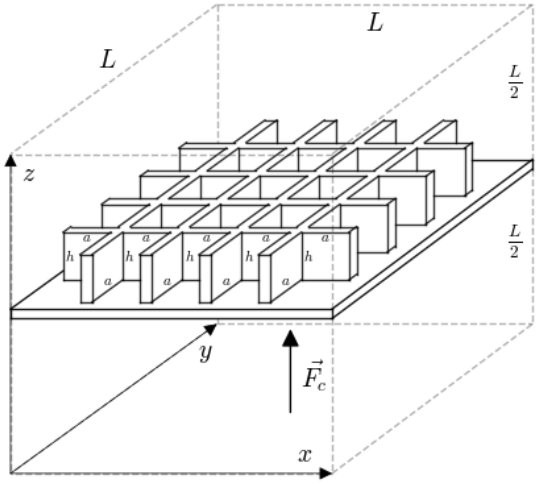


Fig.2. Cubic cavity with a plate covered by honeycomb.

Consider a closed pillbox surface $\partial V_{\rm vac}$ whose faces lie in the free vacuum at $z = \pm L/2$ on either side of the plate (the plate is entirely enclosed, and the lateral faces cancel by in-plane symmetry).

The net force is

$$F_z = \oint_{\partial V_{\rm vac}} \langle T_{zz}\rangle \, da = \left[\langle T_{zz}\rangle_{z=+L/2} - \langle T_{zz}\rangle_{z=-L/2}\right] S.$$

Because the faces lie in the vacuum, this is the flux of the field momentum through a purely vacuum boundary, not a force applied directly to the substance of the plate. The difference is non-zero solely because the mode structure — and hence $\langle T_{zz}\rangle$ — differs on the honeycomb and the smooth side. This is precisely the term omitted when the balance is reduced to $\mathbf{g} = \mathbf{S}/c^2$ with $\langle \mathbf{S}\rangle = 0$.

Quantitatively, the surface integral reproduces the thrust obtained earlier from the difference of specific energy densities [1]: for a gold nano-honeycomb with cell size $a \approx 2\ \mu$m,

$$\frac{F}{S} = \langle T_{zz}\rangle_{\rm honey} - \langle T_{zz}\rangle_{\rm smooth} \approx 8.55\ \text{dyn/m}^2 = 8.55\times 10^{-5}\ \text{N/m}^2,$$

of the order $\langle T_{zz}\rangle \sim K\hbar c/a^4$ with a dimensionless geometric coefficient $K \sim 4\times 10^{-2}$ set by the cell mode structure. Thus the § 105 reading does not re-derive the force but interprets it: the same number is the flux of field momentum through the vacuum boundary.

Where the standard derivation is incomplete.

The passage from volume forces to stresses rests on the Gauss theorem, which Tamm applies (§ 33, eq. 33.7) under the explicit condition that the components of the stress tensor are continuous inside the volume; surfaces of discontinuity are excluded there, and only their surface charges are treated later (§ 34, eq. 34.8). A vacuum–metal boundary of a resonator can carry zero surface charge and still produce a finite jump of the stress tensor: the tensor evaluated with the fields on the vacuum side differs from the one evaluated with the fields inside the wall. On the two sides of such a surface element the stresses are then not equal and opposite. This case is not considered in § 33, nor anywhere in Tamm's book, including § 105. For a volume V that contains internal discontinuity surfaces S_j the Gauss theorem has to be written as

$$\int_V \frac{\partial T_{ik}}{\partial x_k}\, dV = \oint_{\partial V_{\rm ext}} T_{ik}\, n_k\, dS - \sum_j \int_{S_j} [\![T_{ik}]\!]\, n_k\, dS_j,$$

where $[\![\cdot]\!]$ is the jump across S_j. The customary identification of the field momentum with $\mathbf{g} = \mathbf{S}/c^2$ keeps only the external surface integral and drops the jump terms.

The jump on a honeycomb plate. The plate has two such internal boundaries: the bottoms of the cells on the structured side and the smooth face on the other side. The stress on each of them is the electromagnetic pressure of the vacuum modes. Appendix B of [1] computes this pressure on the xy face of an $a\times b\times h$ rectangular resonator, $f_z/S = \int (H_x^2 + H_y^2)\, dS/(8\pi S)$, mode by mode, and relates it to the mode energy density E/V. For a wave propagating along z

$$\frac{f_z/S}{E/V} = 1 \quad \text{(electric mode, } H_z = 0\text{)}, \qquad \frac{f_z/S}{E/V} = \frac{a^2 k_z^2}{a^2 k_z^2 + \pi^2 (n_x^2 + n_y^2)} \quad \text{(magnetic mode, } E_z = 0\text{)},$$

and for every mode type $\lim_{k_z \to \infty} (f_z/S)/(E/V) = 1$. Summed over the zero-point modes, the jump of $\langle T_{zz} \rangle$ across each boundary is therefore fixed by the vacuum energy density of the adjacent cavity, and the difference of the two jumps gives

$$\frac{F}{S} = [\![\langle T_{zz} \rangle]\!]_{\text{honey}} - [\![\langle T_{zz} \rangle]\!]_{\text{smooth}} \;\geq\; \delta \frac{E}{V} = \hbar c \, \pi \frac{R}{a^4},$$

the inequality of [1] (Appendix B). It coincides with the Hamiltonian result $\partial \langle H \rangle / \partial l$ of the previous section. For a gold nano-honeycomb with cell size $a \approx 2$ μm this gives $F/S \approx 8.55$ dyn/m$^2 = 8.55 \times 10^{-5}$ N/m^2. The § 105 reading, completed by the jump terms, therefore does not re-derive the force but locates it: the unbalanced momentum sits in the jump of the vacuum stress tensor on the internal boundaries, which the reduction to $\mathbf{g} = \mathbf{S}/c^2$ drops.

Equivalent pillbox form. Enclosing the whole plate by a pillbox ∂V_{vac} with faces in the free vacuum at $z = \pm d$ (lateral faces cancel by in-plane symmetry) turns the sum of the jumps into an external flux, $F_z = \oint_{\partial V_{\text{vac}}} \langle T_{zz} \rangle \, da = \big[\langle T_{zz} \rangle_{z=+d} - \langle T_{zz} \rangle_{z=-d} \big] S$. This is the flux of field momentum through a purely vacuum boundary, non-zero solely because the mode structure, and hence $\langle T_{zz} \rangle$, differs on the honeycomb and on the smooth side.

Two remarks make the interpretation unambiguous. First, it is the momentum of the field (equivalently, of the material plate that absorbs it), not the total momentum of the closed laboratory system, that is not conserved; the total momentum of plate, field and support is conserved, exactly as for an ordinary sail in a wind. Second, the renormalised vacuum stress $\langle T_{\mu\nu} \rangle$ is a physically measured quantity — the Casimir effect itself — so the jump terms require no assumption of a material aether: their value is fixed by the same $\langle T_{\mu\nu} \rangle$ that is confirmed experimentally for the symmetric configuration. The broken translational symmetry of the boundary conditions, not of space itself, is what renders $\partial \langle H \rangle / \partial l \neq 0$.

CONCLUSION

The Casimir honeycomb drive exemplifies a physical system where Noether's theorem directly explains the origin of macroscopic force: **the lack of spatial homogeneity leads to non-conservation of momentum**, and hence to the appearance of thrust. This demonstrates that quantum vacuum effects are not mere mathematical artifacts but manifestations of deep symmetry principles. Experimental verification can not only confirm the reality of virtual photons but also validate the link between geometry, symmetry, and dynamics in quantum field theory.

ТЕОРЕМА НЕТЕР ТА СТИЛЬНИКОВИЙ РУШІЙ КАЗИМИРА: ПРО НЕЗБЕРЕЖЕННЯ ІМПУЛЬСУ В АСИМЕТРИЧНИХ ВАКУУМНИХ СИСТЕМАХ

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У цій роботі аналізується стильниковий рушій Казимира через призму теореми Нетер. Розглянута система — ідеально провідна пластина з нанорозмірною сотовою структурою з одного боку — не має трансляційної симетрії вздовж осі, нормальної до пластини, через геометричну асиметрію вакуумних мод з двох її сторін. Як наслідок, гамільтоніан вакууму явно залежить від координати l (ефективної довжини резонатора), і, згідно з теоремою Нетер, відповідна компонента імпульсу не зберігається. Це не збереження проявляється як результуюча сила квантового вакууму (тяга Казимира). Показано, що отриманий вираз для сили на одиницю площі безпосередньо відображає цю порушену симетрію й узгоджується як з гамільтоновим підходом, так і з різницею густин енергії. Результат підкреслює глибокий фізичний принцип: макроскопічна тяга від квантових флуктуацій вакууму виникає саме тому, що система не є інваріантною відносно просторових зсувів. Окремо показано, що стандартне застосування рівняння балансу імпульсу (§ 105 Тамма) є неповним для систем із $\langle \mathbf{S} \rangle = 0$: оскільки середній вектор Пойнтінга дорівнює нулю, незбалансований імпульс міститься у поверхневому інтегралі тензора натягів Максвелла по межі вакуумної області, а не у потоці $\mathbf{g} = \mathbf{S}/c^2$. Не зберігається імпульс поля (речовини), а не повний імпульс замкненої системи; величина сили спирається на виміряний вакуумний тензор $\langle T_{\mu\nu} \rangle$ і не потребує припущення про матеріальний ефір.

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